

Task 5: Cyberbullying

Part:1 Case Study on UPI and Online Payment Fraud

Title: Deceptive UPI Request Scams Targeting Students

Unified Payments Interface (UPI) fraud has emerged as a rapidly growing cybercrime in India, primarily fueled by social engineering tactics rather than technical exploits. A common method involves the use of deceptive "collect requests."

The Scam Scenario

In a typical case, a college student listing a second-hand laptop for sale is contacted by a scammer posing as a legitimate buyer. To build trust, the scammer agrees to the asking price without negotiation. However, instead of transferring funds, the attacker sends a "collect request" through apps like PhonePe or Google Pay. Misinterpreting this as a notification to receive money, the student enters their UPI PIN, which unknowingly authorizes a debit transaction that instantly transfers funds to the scammer.

Target Audience and Tactics

This type of fraud frequently targets students, freelancers, online sellers, and those unfamiliar with digital payment systems. Attackers leverage a lack of technical awareness, misplaced trust, and a sense of urgency, often using phrases like "pay now to confirm" to pressure victims.

Impact and Consequences

The results of such scams include immediate financial loss, psychological distress, and the risk of being targeted again. If multiple requests are approved, victims can lose their entire bank balance in mere minutes. Recovery of these funds is often extremely difficult.

Conclusion

This case highlights that UPI fraud is driven more by user behavior than system vulnerabilities. Consequently, improving digital literacy is the most essential tool for preventing such deceptive practices.